
DONUT: Design and Optimization of Non-axisymmetric Unified Tori

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Abstract

1 DONUT is a computational geometry tool for optimising stellarator-type fusion re-
2 actors. It generates toroidal, non-axisymmetric plasma surfaces and coil geometries,
3 enabling researchers to design and optimize complex 3D magnetic confinement
4 systems.

5 Nomenclature

6	α	Twist parameter
7	$\bar{\delta}$	Average triangularity
8	$\bar{\iota}$	Edge rotational transform over number of field periods
9	$\epsilon_{\max}$	Maximum elongation
10	ϕ	Toroidal angle
11	ϕ_i	azimuthal angle
12	ϕ_t	Toroidal spherical coordinate polar angle
13	ψ_p	Poloidal circular coordinate angle
14	N_p	Number of poloidal sections
15	N_t	Number of toroidal sections
16	θ	Poloidal angle
17	θ_i	polar angle
18	θ_t	Toroidal spherical coordinate angle
19	A	Aspect ratio
20	m	knot count relationship
21	n	number of control points
22	$N_{i,q}(u)$	B-spline basis functions of degree q
23	P_i	NURBS control points
24	r_i	radial distance
25	r_p	Poloidal circular coordinate radius
26	r_t	Toroidal spherical coordinate azimuthal radius
27	s_t	Parametric poloidal section location
28	$u_0, u_1, \dots, u_m$	knot vector
29	w_i	NURBS associated weights
30	w_p	Poloidal NURBS associated weights
31	w_t	Toroidal NURBS weight

1 Introduction

The optimisation of stellarator plasma geometry is a central challenge in modern magnetic confinement fusion research. Unlike tokamaks, which rely partly on plasma current to generate rotational transform, stellarators achieve plasma confinement entirely through externally generated three-dimensional magnetic fields [18]. This intrinsic steady-state capability makes stellarators attractive candidates for future fusion reactors, particularly because they avoid many of the current-driven instabilities [4] [14] [7] [13] [1] [17] [8] and disruption risks [12] [6] [3] [15] [10] [9] [16] associated with tokamaks. However, the absence of axisymmetry introduces substantial geometric complexity, requiring careful optimisation of magnetic surfaces, coil configurations, and plasma equilibrium properties.

In stellarator design, plasma geometry strongly influences confinement quality, neoclassical transport, magnetohydrodynamic (MHD) stability, energetic particle confinement, and engineering feasibility. The shape of the plasma boundary determines the structure of magnetic field lines and the resulting particle trajectories, making geometric optimisation a multidimensional problem involving both physics performance and practical constraints. Modern stellarator optimisation therefore seeks configurations that simultaneously minimise transport losses, improve stability, reduce bootstrap current, and maintain realizable coil geometries.

[5] is a recent example of a stellarator optimisation code that provides a dataset of optimized or partially optimized stellarator plasma boundary configurations that exhibit quasi-isodynamic (QI)-like properties. It defines the geometry using a Fourier surface representation in cylindrical coordinates, where the boundary shape is parameterized by Fourier coefficients for the radial $R(\theta, \phi)$ and vertical $Z(\theta, \phi)$ components. The current work targets the multi-objective constrained optimisation problem, in particular the Geometry problem, by using an alternative plasma boundary representation based on Non-Uniform Rational B-Splines (NURBS). This approach allows for higher geometric expressivity and has the natural ability to enforce constraints. It is also easier to encode Computer Aided Design (CAD) logic, enabling seamless integration with engineering design workflows.

In future work, this geometry will be used to define the computational domain for a GPU-accelerated MHD equilibrium solver that operates in physical space rather than flux coordinates to solve for MHD equilibrium. Minimum normalised magnetic gradient scale length can then be used for Simple-to-build QI and MHD-stable-QI type problems. The source code of this work is available at <https://github.com/DjgentleViBe/DONUT>.

2 Geometry

The Geometric problem is originally defined as:

$$\min_{\theta} \epsilon_{\max} \quad (1)$$

$$\text{s.t. } A \leq A^*, \quad (2)$$

$$\bar{\delta} \leq \bar{\delta}^*, \quad (3)$$

$$\bar{t} \leq \bar{t}^* \quad (4)$$

A plasma boundary is defined by the coefficients R_{mn} and Z_{mn} of a truncated Fourier series in cylindrical coordinates, parameterized by θ and ϕ given in Appendix A

In this paper, the plasma boundary is defined instead by first constructing a 3D NURBS curve from points expressed in spherical coordinates. This serves as the basis for the toroidal path. Using this basis curve, the toroidal geometry can be constructed using three different approaches:

- **Type 1** - A prescribed number of poloidal cross-sections are then generated, each represented as a closed 2D NURBS loop. Finally, these sections are lofted along the 3D guiding curve, with the assumption of tangentiality at each poloidal section, to form the complete geometry.
- **Type 2** - A single poloidal base cross-section is defined using a closed 2D NURBS curve. A twist parameter is then specified along the 3D guide curve. The base cross-section is lofted

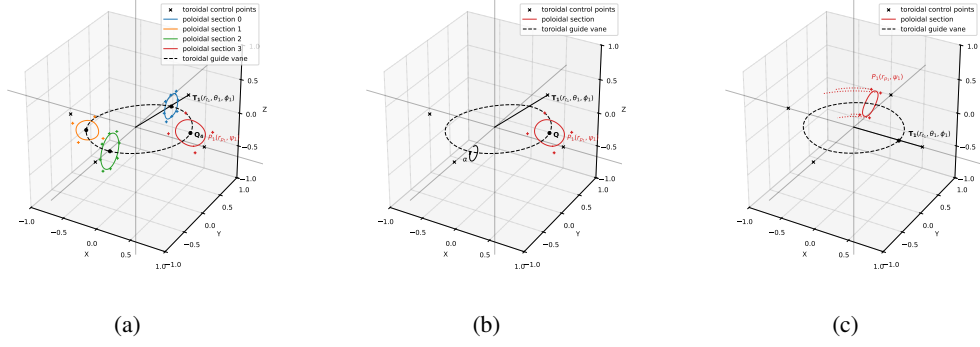


Figure 1: (a) Type 1 geometry generated with four poloidal cross section ($Q_1, \dots, Q_4$) definitions and four 3D control points ($T_1, \dots, T_4$) in spherical coordinate system for the toroidal guide vane. The poloidal section at Q_4 consists of four 2D control points in circular coordinate system. Each poloidal section is moved by rotating along the guide vane with its orientation perpendicular to the tangent at that guide vane point. Only Q_4 and T_1 are depicted. (b) Type 2 geometry with poloidal section lofted along the 3D toroidal spline with twist parameter α defined along the 3D guide vane. (c) Type 3 geometry with spatially varying $P(r_p, \psi)$ along the toroidal guide vane.

77 along the guide vane, while twist and scaling transformations are applied about the local
78 tangential direction.

$$\alpha(t) = k \cdot t \cdot \frac{2\pi}{N} + B \cdot \sin \frac{N \cdot t \cdot 2\pi}{N_t} \quad (5)$$

- 79 • **Type 3** - The r_p and ψ parameters defining the 2D spline are treated as spatially varying
80 functions along the guide vane.
- 81 • **Type 4** - A candidate geometry is represented as the union of N spherical primitives,
82 each defined by its centre coordinates and radius (x_i, y_i, z_i, r_i) . The parameters of all
83 spheres form the chromosome used by the genetic algorithm. Geometric variation is
84 achieved by modifying sphere positions and radii, allowing both shape and topology changes
85 during optimisation. Compared with voxel-based encodings, sphere-based representations
86 provide a more compact design space while retaining the ability to represent complex three-
87 dimensional geometries. Similar primitive-based approaches have been used in evolutionary
88 shape optimisation and explicit topology optimisation frameworks such as those of [2] [11].

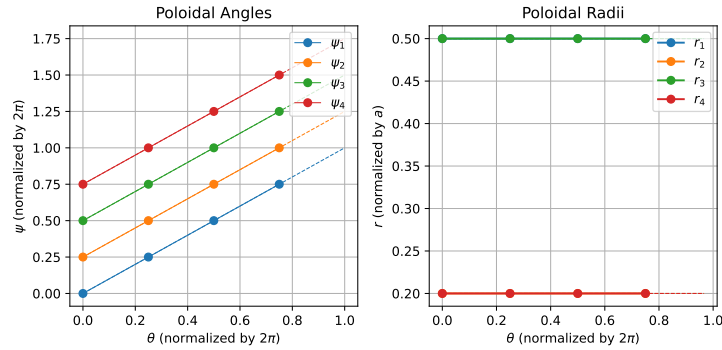


Figure 2: Fitting NURBS curve for ψ and r values of Type 3 geometry. Periodic representations require the last point to be adjusted accordingly.

Table 1: Maximum elongation across different geometry types after optimization using Gradient based methods.

	Type 1		Type 2		Type 3	
	$\epsilon_{\text{init}} = 4.8509$		$\epsilon_{\text{init}} = 1.4985$		$\epsilon_{\text{init}} = 2.6161$	
Optimiser	nfev	ϵ_{max}	nfev	ϵ_{max}	nfev	ϵ_{max}
L-BFGS-B	372	3.0968	672	1.3620	69	2.6161
Nelder-Mead	95	4.3647	88	1.3766	70	2.6152
Trust-constr	186	4.7543	64	1.4617	138	1.4992
COBYLA	184	2.7906	62	1.1257	136	1.7699
COBYQA	188	3.7076	66	1.2460	140	2.6151
SLSQP	283	3.5246	101	1.1341		
Powell	184	4.0724	62	1.4957	136	2.6156

89 3 Optimisation

90 A NURBS curve of degree p is defined as:

$$\mathbf{C}(u) = \frac{\sum_{i=0}^n N_{i,q}(u) w_i \mathbf{P}_i}{\sum_{i=0}^n N_{i,q}(u) w_i}, \quad u \in [u_0, u_m]. \quad (6)$$

91 The control points $\mathbf{P}_i$ are defined in spherical coordinates and transformed into Cartesian space as

$$\mathbf{P}_i = \begin{bmatrix} r_i \sin \theta_i \cos \phi_i \\ r_i \sin \theta_i \sin \phi_i \\ r_i \cos \theta_i \end{bmatrix},$$

92 3.1 Gradient based methods

93 The following variables are parametrisable: $(\theta_t, \phi_t, r_t, w_t)_{N_t}$, $(s_t, \psi_p, r_p, w_p)_{N_p}$. The objective
 94 function from Equation 1 is used along with constraint equations 2 and 3 for the non-linear opti-
 95 misation problem. Equation 4 is irrelevant as rotational edge transform is naturally encoded in the
 96 poloidal section. Solutions obtained using Scipy algorithms SLSQP, L-BFGS-G, COBYLA, COBYQA,
 97 Nelder-Mead, trust-constr and Powell are provided. For trust-constr and SLSQP, con-
 98 straints are modelled as Non-Linear representations while for others it is included as a penalty term
 99 in the objective function.

100 3.2 Genetic Algorithm

101 3.3 Neural Networks

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A Fourier Geometry

$$R(\theta, \phi) = \sum_{n=-N}^N \sum_{m=0}^M R_{mn} \cos(m\theta - nN_{fp}\phi) \quad (7)$$

$$Z(\theta, \phi) = \sum_{n=-N}^N \sum_{m=0}^M Z_{mn} \sin(m\theta - nN_{fp}\phi) \quad (8)$$